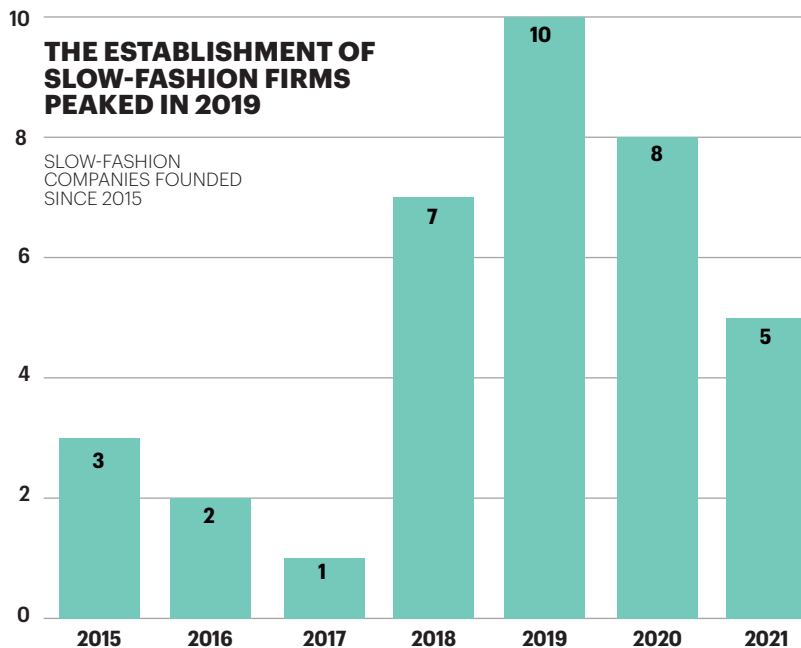


Spencer, among others—which introduce more than 50 ‘micro seasons’ a year to entice consumers to change their collection every week—have fuelled the unsustainable consumption rate and demand growth for apparel. The business model is built around short runs of products that are not repeated, which means they only produce what the customers demand, but in a limited quantity. This fit-to-demand model ensures that there is rarely any surplus, but it also means that demand is kept alive for newer products, fuelling the unsustainability of fast fashion.

BUT SLOWLY, these mass-market brands have started to undertake measures towards sustainability following the popularity of niche sustainable brands. “Zara and Inditex, our parent company, create and produce fashion that people desire, and we do so in an increasingly sustainable way. Our business model is interesting since we are known for not advertising, and the model is based on producing strictly what the customers demand. This fit-to-demand model ensures that we make what is required, rather than push to sell what is made,” a senior Zara spokesperson told *Business Today*.

The company adds that it is increasing the use of more sustainable materials, better textile processes and promoting circularity. “We are committed to ensuring that 100 per cent of the cotton used in our garments will be more sustainable, organic, or recycled from next year. In addition, polyester and linen used in our products will be recycled, or come from more sustainable sources by 2025,” the spokesperson adds.

There’s pressure on bigger brands due to the environmental, social and governance (ESG) movement, says Anand Ramanathan,



■ TOTAL NUMBER OF COMPANIES
SOURCE TRACXN



“From the use of plant-based textiles and bacteria-based dyes to deploying a blockchain-based supply chain to increase transparency, we aim to stay sustainable at every step of the way”

MANMOHAN SINGH
HEAD, BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT,
BIRLA CELLULOSE

Senior Partner at Deloitte India. “Start-ups like Bombay Trooper are niche but globally relevant, but even large fashion houses will eventually move towards it [ESG]. They’ll both move in tandem, and local brands will always be more relevant,” he adds. Highlighting the ways in which the value chain can be made more sustainable, he says that processes like traceability of sourced products, crop growing patterns, smart manufacturing processes to reduce wastage, and D2C e-commerce can be reimagined using innovative technology.

Navin S. Rao, Co-founder of women’s loungewear brand The Kaftan Company, agrees. From selection of natural and non-animal-based fabrics to digital printing and sustainable dyeing methods, he calls sustainability a work in progress, and talks about experimenting with new-age fabrics made of hemp and bamboo fibre, along with 3D printed textile. “We don’t churn out products at the same rate as some